

## **REQUEST FOR FUNDS**

TO Ohio Department of Health  
FROM Cuyahoga County Board of Health  
SUBJECT PeerLift Pilot: High School Peer Counseling Program and Center

### **Background**

The United States is in the middle of a youth mental health crisis. In 2021, 35% of Cuyahoga County high school students reported feelings of persistent sadness or hopelessness (Prevention Research Center for Healthy Neighborhoods, n.d.). According to the CDC's 2023 Youth Risk Behavior Survey, 20% of high school students reported seriously considering committing suicide, with 9% of high school students reported attempting suicide (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention [CDC] 2024). Adolescents need more mental health support, but the resources are not available to many of them. 20% of adolescents, ages 12-17, report that they have received mental health therapy, but another 20% of adolescents report having unmet mental health care needs (CDC 2024).

A growing model in youth mental health promotion is peer support. Peer support models involve training students in mental health literacy and communication to become mentors who can assist other students. Adolescents, in particular, can struggle to connect with traditional therapies and often turn to informal sources of support in their friends. Peer support models fill this gap and recognize the importance of social interaction between adolescents (California Children's Trust, 2022). Peer support does not replace traditional therapies but can complement existing mental health services in schools by focusing on early intervention and prevention (California Children's Trust, 2022). Peer support models show promise in improving mental health outcomes while being more accessible and affordable than traditional therapies. For young adults, the research shows that peer support can have a positive impact on depressive symptoms, anxiety, psychological distress, and self-esteem (Richard et al., 2022). Peer support at the high school level is a burgeoning model, and much of the research is focused on college-aged young adults; however, the high-school-specific research available is promising and reflects the outcomes experienced by college-aged youth (Dodd, 2022). Peer support models combat growing adolescent isolation by encouraging students to form relationships and a broader community with their peers, making them feel more connected to their community.

The rise in peer support interventions is also attributed to shortages in the behavioral health workforce. In Ohio the need for behavioral health professionals is only growing. From 2013 to 2019, the demand for mental health services increased by 353%, while 41-46% of the need was still unmet in 2021 (The Ohio Council of Behavioral Health and Family Services Providers, 2025). Therefore, high-school-based peer

support models can potentially improve the behavioral health workforce longterm through exposure. Being a peer counselor allows students to experience what working in behavioral health might be like and could lead to more health professionals in the field. The proposal before you aims to combat the growing adolescent mental health crisis with a model that improves social connectedness. Additionally, the program nurtures the flailing behavioral health workforce by developing a pipeline to the field.

### **Proposal**

**The Cuyahoga County Board of Health respectfully requests \$992,000, over three years, from the Ohio Department of Health (ODH) to pilot PeerLift, a high school peer counseling program and on-campus center, in five Cuyahoga County public schools. PeerLift aims to support ODH's Adolescent Health Program.**

PeerLift is designed to prevent the adverse mental health impacts of adolescent loneliness and isolation by using an in-school peer support model. PeerLift also aims to address Ohio's behavioral health workforce shortages by building a pipeline between PeerLift Peer Counselors and higher education institutions offering undergraduate degrees in behavioral health fields. *CCBH's vision for the Future of Social Interaction is one where discussion of mental health challenges amongst youth is not stigmatized and high schools have the infrastructure to develop peer-to-peer connections that are health promoting.*

PeerLift includes three major components:

- 1) A Peer Counseling Center staffed by high school students who have completed a year-long, in-school Peer Counseling course.
- 2) A mobile device application that acts as an out-of-school companion to the Peer Counseling Center.
  - a) The application will include a library of mental health resources, a scheduling feature to make appointments at the Peer Counseling Center, and a secure messaging system where students can chat with a peer counselor outside the center.
- 3) A scholarship to Case Western Reserve University's Mandel School of Applied Social Sciences for Peer Counselors who have completed 120 hours of peer counseling and received a 3.5 GPA or higher. This would be guaranteed, upon admittance to the University.

## **Funding Approach**

CCBH is requesting \$992,000 from the Ohio Department of Health (ODH) to launch PeerLift (\$489,000 in Y1, \$209,000 in Y2, and \$294,000 in Y3).

### **Detailed Budget Breakdown**

- PeerLift Project Manager: \$264,000 (\$88,000 per annum) is budgeted for the project manager's salary and fringe benefits across three years to oversee the execution and maintain alignment with our objectives. The PeerLift Project Manager will be an employee of CCBH.
- Contract for Mobile Application Development: \$340,000 (\$260,000 in Y1, \$40,000 in Y2, \$40,000 in Y3)
  - *Lead Developer and Development Team*: \$220,000 is designated for the lead developer and development team to create a mobile app facilitating secure student communication.
  - *Application Hosting and Maintenance*: \$120,000 covers application hosting, ongoing maintenance, updates by 1-2 dedicated staff members in years two and three, plus server fees and other related costs. (\$40,000 per annum over 3 years)
- Teacher Stipends: \$150,000 is allocated to compensate five teachers over three years at five high schools, with each teacher receiving \$10,000 per year for their role in the Peer Counseling Center.
- Evaluation Contract: \$50,000 supports hiring the Schubert Center for Child Studies at Case Western Reserve University to assist the Project Manager in developing program evaluation metrics in Y1.
- Peer Counseling Center Setup: \$15,000 is distributed among five schools, with \$3,000 per school in Y2 to set up the necessary infrastructure for Center setup.
- Curriculum Development and Licensing: \$30,000 in Y1 reserved for developing and licensing curriculum content for the Peer Counseling Course.
- Scholarships: \$100,000 is designated in Y3 to provide scholarships to qualifying Peer Counselors.
- Community Events: \$30,000 is budgeted for events to engage the community and raise awareness about the program (\$15,000 in Y2 and \$15,000 in Y3).
- Miscellaneous Expenses: To cover unforeseen costs, \$10,000 is allocated.
- Domestic Travel: \$3,000 is budgeted for travel related to program management and site visits, ensuring effective oversight and engagement with all participating schools (\$1,000 per annum).

## **Implementation Plan**

### **YEAR ONE - SCHOOL YEAR 2025/2026**

Year one of the PeerLift pilot will be dedicated to developing the program infrastructure. The majority of grant funds will be designated for hiring a PeerLift Project Manager who will be housed at the Cuyahoga County Board of Health and for developing a mobile device application that will accompany PeerLift's in-school services.

The PeerLift Project Manager will use a request for proposals (RFP) process to select five Cuyahoga County public schools as PeerLift pilot sites. These sites will identify a teacher on staff trained to teach a year-long Peer Counseling course and act as the advisor to the Peer Counseling Center that will launch in year two. The teacher training program will be four weeks long before the start of the school year in August 2025. Teachers will receive an annual stipend for their participation in the pilot. Courses will be available to sophomores and juniors in the fall of 2025. The PeerLift Project Manager will convene all Peer Counseling teachers formally four additional times throughout the school year to support peer learning, receive feedback, and offer assistance. The Project Manager will also be available to respond to teachers and school-systems' needs informally throughout the year.

Concurrently, the PeerLift Project Manager will use an RFP process to select a mobile app developer that will create a mobile device application that students will use outside of the Peer Counseling Center to access a library of mental health resources, schedule Counseling Center appointments, and chat with a Peer Counselor through direct messaging. The selected mobile app developer will be required to work, in some capacity, with the students in the Fall 2025 peer counseling course to ensure the app meets its end users' needs. The application will be ready to be formally launched by the school year 2026/2027.

### **YEAR TWO - SCHOOL YEAR 2026/2027**

Year two of PeerLift pilot grant funds will be dedicated to continuing in-school peer counseling classes and the start-up of the in-school Peer Counseling Centers. In year two, the PeerLift Project Manager will hold a training session on establishing an in-school Peer Counseling Center. This training will include best practices for Peer Counselor selection, Peer Counseling Center governance, and Peer Counseling Center policies and procedures. The Project Manager will continue to convene the Peer Counseling teachers formally four times a year and be available informally. The Peer Counseling teachers/Center advisors will select their Peer Counselors in September of 2026 from the pool of students who have completed the Peer Counseling course. Center advisors will work with those students to develop their school-specific Center. The Peer Counseling Centers will formally launch in January 2027 following winter break. The mobile app will launch simultaneously.

### YEAR THREE - SCHOOL YEAR 2027/2028

Year three of PeerLift pilot grant funds will be dedicated to the continuation of in-school Peer Counseling classes, the operation of the Peer Counseling Center, mobile app maintenance, and the launch of a partnership with the CWRU Mandel School of Applied Social Sciences. In year three of the pilot, PeerLift aims to address behavioral health workforce shortages by incentivizing high-performing Peer Counselors to pursue degrees in behavioral health. Peer Counselors who have completed 120 hours of peer counseling and have earned a 3.5 GPA or higher will receive CWRU college credit and a guaranteed scholarship of no less than \$5,000 from PeerLift upon admittance to the University. Scholarships will be administered by CCBH. The Project Manager will continue to convene the Peer Counseling teachers formally four times a year and be available to them informally until the pilot concludes.

### **Evaluation**

The evaluation of PeerLift will be conducted in two parts: internal metrics for quality improvement and external metrics for efficacy evaluation. To determine the quality of peer counselors, educators in our chosen schools will fill out surveys of how well they see the peer counselor programs as making a difference and how confident the peer counselors feel in themselves. If there is an overall positive response, we will increase the number of counselors; training will be adjusted if there is a negative response. Additionally, we will pull times of student log-ins in Year One to determine trends in utilization and create the staffing model for Year Two and Year Three, accordingly. Within the app, on the peer counselor side, there will be an option to send a referral for a student to the school counselor. By comparing the referral numbers through the app to pre-program referral numbers, the internal effectiveness of the program will be evaluated.

To evaluate the effectiveness of the program, we will partner with associates from the Schubert Center for Child Studies due to their specialized skill set in working with youth for summers before and after Year One to adapt existing screening tools to create a behavioral health survey for our chosen high schools and to help analyze the initial data. This survey will be administered to students before the program begins and at the end of each year. To incentivize completion, there will be a tiered raffle giveaway among the students that completed it, with third place receiving a \$50 VISA gift card, second place receiving a \$100 VISA gift card, and first place receiving a \$250 VISA gift card. Additionally, a qualitative survey will be administered before and after each of the four community-facing events to look at the success of our educational sessions.

**Proposed Budget**

| <b>Item</b>                                | <b>ODH Request</b> |
|--------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>Personnel Expenses</b>                  |                    |
| <i>Salaries and Wages</i>                  |                    |
| PeerLift Project Manager                   | \$240,000          |
| <i>Fringe Benefits</i>                     |                    |
| PeerLift Project Manager                   | \$24,000           |
| <b>Non-Personnel Expenses</b>              |                    |
| <i>Contract Services/Professional Fees</i> |                    |
| Contract Lead Mobile App Developer         | \$120,000          |
| Contract Mobile App Development Team       | \$100,000          |
| Application hosting and Maintenance        | \$120,000          |
| Teacher Stipend                            | \$150,000          |
| Evaluation Programming                     | \$50,000           |
| <i>Educational Equipment and Supplies</i>  |                    |
| Classroom Setup                            | \$15,000           |
| Curriculum Development and Licensing       | \$30,000           |
| Scholarship                                | \$100,000          |
| <b>Other</b>                               |                    |
| Domestic Travel                            | \$3,000            |
| Community Events                           | \$30,000           |
| Miscellaneous                              | \$10,000           |
| <b>Total Project Expenses</b>              | <b>\$992,000</b>   |

## References

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